

fighting were common, and so was extortion in public view. Disputes over land led to the rise of organized gangs, and rival groups periodically took on each other in broad daylight with crude revolvers, hockey sticks and cycle chains. In many ways, Dombivli was turning out to be worse than Bhandup on the crime graph.

For somebody like me, who could be provoked easily and was not averse to violence, it was a struggle to stay out of trouble and resist the lure of bad company. I had learnt a few things during my association with Shankar and Arthur, and more than once it crossed my mind to moonlight for one of the local *dadas* of Dombivli.

But the enormous daily inconvenience that Bauji was enduring just to keep me on the straight and narrow somehow stirred my conscience. That Satish and Anju still looked up to me embarrassed me, and yet I was pressured by what I thought was my responsibility towards them. Torn inwardly, I kept to a small group of friends and to my studies in college.

I was in the twelfth standard when Bauji had an accident at the factory that left him physically disabled for a while. It would be ten months before Bauji was able to get back to work. The last two and a half months of his confinement at home were without pay. That period was very tough on all of us, emotionally as well as financially; at one stage, we were not sure if his foot would recover fully to enable him to resume work as before.

This incident snuffed out whatever little temptation I had left for murky adventures. The last thing I wanted to do was add to the problems at home.

I worked as an assistant in a revolving library called *Yogayog* near Dombivli railway station for some months. The money was not much, but every rupee counted at that time. The best thing about the job was it introduced me to the world of books. Until then, I had not really enjoyed reading. I used to put in four hours daily at the library, and with enough spare time on my hands, gradually took to reading. I began with the thrillers and graduated to the classics. My reading habit that I accidentally picked up grew stronger over the years and was to help me immensely in my career in the stock market.

An attempt to seek my fortune in the Gulf after graduation ended in disappointment. Bauji had paid a recruitment agent Rs 15,000 for a clerical position for me in a trading firm in Dubai, but the agent never delivered on his promise. Left with little choice, I briefly assumed my old avatar to get